

informs Chandramohan.

"Trend is towards more and more fine pitch and chip capacity. Also, the speed expectations of the customers are rising steadily," says Gurjal.

"SMT machines are designed for low noise level, and the smoke coming out of the reflow oven is against the eco-system. But in new machines, this is controlled using filters," adds Krishnakumar.

"In SMT printers, in-line machines are being preferred to standalone printers. In pick-and-place, all-purpose mounters (multi-function mounters) and speeds as usual are the deciding criteria. Of course, high-end EMS companies look for very high-speed chip shooters. In conveyerised reflow ovens, demand is for seven-to ten-zone depending on the volume of manufacturing," informs L. Sampath, CEO, 3EMST Marketing.

There are ample indicators for



RF300 three-zone conveyerised reflow oven from Juki

strong growth in the SMT placement, screen printers, soldering and inspection equipment product markets.

"Equipment that are in demand include component placement systems, auto insertion machines, printers, ovens, wave-soldering machines and AOI. Barring entry-level ovens and wave-soldering machines, all equipment are imported," says Suresh Nair, director-sales & marketing, Leaptech

Corporation.

Specifically, pick-and-place machines are in large demand today. "These equipment are imported from Switzerland, Japan and USA as we do not have indigenous technology today to manufacture them," says Krishnakumar.

"The same is the case for high-end Stecil printers. However, reflow machines made in India are sold in good quantities," adds Gurjal.

Why do we depend on imports?

"There is no major equipment manufacturing happening in India. The equipment are high-technology, and except for some peripheral equipment, all the machines continue to be imported," informs Chandramohan.

"We manufacture SMT machines for low to mid volume only, but when it comes to precision and accuracy we are dependent on imports. We, the SMT equipment manufacturers, give the patented technology or cross-licence the high-tech manufacturing equipment. As a buyer, we could have good price advantages clubbed with best services," says Krishnakumar.

In SMT printers, in-line machines are being preferred to standalone printers—L. Sampath, CEO, 3EMST Marketing



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